MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 4 — Unit 1: Historicising The Canterbury Tales

CHAUCER TO THE ELIZABETHAN AGE

Expanded exam notes · Simple explanations + developed discussion

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material (M21EG01DC). These are study aids, not the original textbook. Everyday comparisons are teaching examples. The original notes and full textbook units remain available in the subject folder.

The chapter in one sentence

To historicise *The Canterbury Tales* is to study how its language, audience, characters, and stories relate to the changing society in which Chaucer wrote.

Start with a picture

Imagine finding an old school photograph. You might ask what the uniforms show, who could attend the school, and who is missing. Now imagine a drawing made to poke fun at the school. It tells you something about school life, but it is also selected and shaped by an artist.

Chaucer’s poem is closer to the shaped representation than a neutral record.

1. What does “historicise” mean?

It means placing a work within its historical conditions. Ask about work, class, religion, gender, language, and the production and circulation of writing.

This differs from merely memorising dates. The aim is to explain how historical conditions affect literary meaning.

2. Chaucer lived in more than a literary world

Chaucer’s public employment and political connections matter. Writing was not necessarily a separate modern profession in which an author earned a living only by selling books.

His experience of administration, travel, and social relationships helps us frame questions about the worlds his poetry brings together. It does not mean every character is a disguised portrait of a real acquaintance.

3. Who could encounter his work?

Manuscripts were copied by hand. Literacy, money, occupation, and social networks affected access. Listening to a reading could also give someone access to a text without private ownership of a book.

Chaucer died before Caxton’s English printing press. Avoid imagining him publishing books in a modern shop or writing for an internet-sized public.

Different groups used different languages: Latin had religious and learned functions, French carried aristocratic and administrative prestige, and English was becoming increasingly important in literary culture.

4. Estates: society imagined as groups with duties

Medieval social thinking often distinguished those who pray, those who fight, and those who work. Actual society was more complicated, including merchants, officials, and different urban groups.

Estates satire examines whether people fulfil the responsibilities of their position. A religious figure who values luxury over service becomes a target because behaviour and duty do not match.

5. Is the pilgrimage a complete picture of society?

No. It is a literary selection. Its middle social strata are richly represented, while other groups are absent or unevenly represented. Characters can draw on inherited stereotypes as well as observation.

The phrase “mirror of society” is useful only if qualified: a literary mirror can select, distort, criticise, and rearrange.

6. Work and position shape voices

A pilgrim’s occupation influences habits, values, and storytelling. The Knight’s narrative interests differ from those of other pilgrims. Their stories and interruptions make social differences audible.

Imagine classmates describing the same school day: a team captain, a new student, and a librarian may notice different things because they occupy different roles.

7. Hierarchy is both present and unsettled

The journey brings people of different ranks into a shared space. Respect, rivalry, argument, and storytelling can reinforce rank or challenge it. The pilgrimage imagines fellowship without erasing conflict.

The Wife of Bath raises questions about experience, marriage, and male authority. The Pardoner complicates expectations about moral and social identity. These figures encourage analysis rather than simple labels.

Key terms

- **Historical context:** the conditions surrounding a work’s production and reception.
- **Representation:** a constructed portrayal of something.
- **Hierarchy:** an arrangement of people or groups by rank.
- **Reception:** how audiences encounter and interpret a work.

Build an exam answer

Make a claim about social change, support it with a pilgrim or storytelling exchange, and explain how literary technique shapes that evidence. Do not use the poem as if it were a census.

Quick check

1. Is historicising just giving Chaucer's birth date? **No; it explains relationships between text and historical conditions.**
2. Could a non-owner encounter a manuscript text? **Yes, for example by hearing a reading.**
3. Does literary realism guarantee a neutral record? **No; selection, convention, and satire shape representation.**

Develop an exam answer

Practice question

Why must The Canterbury Tales be read as a historical representation rather than a transparent record?

Expanded discussion

Historicising The Canterbury Tales means examining the conditions under which it was written, circulated, and understood. Chaucer's world included several languages, uneven literacy, manuscript production, and opportunities for oral reception. Readers and listeners were not a single uniform public. Occupation, wealth, education, and social connection influenced access to literature and shaped expectations about it.

The pilgrims' occupations and ranks create a vivid encounter with social difference, but vividness must not be mistaken for statistical completeness. Chaucer selects figures, draws on literary conventions, and uses irony and satire. The poem does not represent every group in proportion to its presence in medieval society. Its historical value lies partly in the ways it organises attitudes towards work, religious responsibility, and public behaviour.

Estates satire offers one framework for understanding this organisation. Readers can compare a figure's conduct with the duties attached to that social role. Yet the pilgrimage also brings different voices into a shared narrative space where rank can be challenged. Interruptions, disagreement, and competing stories suggest that social hierarchy is not the only force shaping interaction. The possibility of fellowship coexists with rivalry and resentment.

Characters such as the Wife of Bath make questions of gender and authority especially visible. Their significance cannot be captured by simply assigning them a fixed social label. A historicised reading asks how inherited expectations are repeated, tested, or unsettled through literary form. This approach uses the poem as evidence of cultural meanings while recognising that it actively constructs the world it presents.

Suggested answer structure

1. Define historicising
2. Languages, literacy, and manuscripts
3. Selection and estates satire
4. Pilgrimage, hierarchy, and social exchange
5. Gender and the limits of the mirror metaphor

Common mistakes to avoid

Do not place Chaucer in Caxton’s printing culture as a living participant. The poem is not a census, and its narrator is not a neutral historian.

Turn this into your own answer

Read the question again and choose only relevant sections. Make one clear point per paragraph, explain it, and connect it with a specific textual detail. Add accurate short quotations from the textbook where useful; the discussion above is paraphrase, not quoted text. Adjust length to the marks and time available.

Coverage review: extra exam details

A useful chain for critical writing

Historical conditions influence access to literature; access helps shape audiences; audiences bring expectations; literary choices work with or against those expectations. Apply this chain to the use of English, manuscript circulation, oral reception, and occupational identities. Avoid claiming that the precise size or composition of Chaucer’s actual audience is fully known.

Chaucer’s administrative and court connections offer a context for understanding social observation. They do not prove that every fictional pilgrim corresponds to one real acquaintance. The relationship between class position and narrative method needs an argument, not a speculative identification.

The critical discussion associated with Jill Mann emphasises how work and social experience inform conduct. An estates label can explain an expectation, but individual behaviour may disturb that label. The pilgrimage’s fellowship is thus both a framework of shared purpose and a space where difference becomes audible. Use a specific portrait or storytelling exchange to demonstrate that tension.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts, included as a revision checklist, not as predictions of the exam. Longer answers still need evidence from the assigned texts.

1. How does The Canterbury Tales implicate mediaeval class structures?
2. In what way is Chaucer’s own social position interwoven into the narrative of The Canterbury Tales?
3. Examine the representation of the pilgrims in The Canterbury Tales.